When we turned into Frankfurter Allee there were hundreds of policemen and soldiers busy clearing away rubble from the latest heavy bombing raid. It was too late to turn back. But apparently, nobody got suspicious. We reached Siegfriedstraße near Berlin-Lichtenberg railway station. From there we wanted to go to an uncle of Erich Hanke in the Wotanstraße, but he was not at home. Nearby there was a bombed-out house where we got rid of the eye-catching stripes on our prison clothes. Now we looked like foreign workers.

Soaked by rain, they roamed the streets of Lichtenberg and Neukölln in constant danger of being caught as they sought shelter with friends who were either not there or whose apartments had been bombed out. Without identity papers and money, the fugitives could use neither the underground, tram nor bus. 'Besides,' Honecker said, 'public transport was frequently put out of operation by bombing raids.'12 Their first night was spent huddled in the basement of a gutted tenement in Hallesches Tor, where they snatched what rest they could. When they awoke the next morning, the pair went their separate ways. Exhausted and desperately cold, Honecker made a short journey across the rubble-strewn streets to Landsberger Straße and the apartment of his lover, Charlotte Schanuel. However, conscious of the possibility of being discovered and handed to the Gestapo, Charlotte spirited him back to the women's prison a week later. With some luck, he was never punished, despite his absence having been reported by Hauptsturmführer Seraphim, an over-zealous SS man. 'The acting Attorney General at the Berlin Court of Appeal stood up for me against Seraphim,' Honecker later explained. 'So, I was lucky in my misfortune.' (In fact, the wheels had been set in motion for an arrest warrant, but the document was destroyed during an air raid). Predictably, though, his escape caused a rumpus in the KPD group at Görden and he was called to provide an account before a cadre commission, which, after much debate, exonerated him as no 'retaliatory measures' were inflicted on his comrades.13 In later life, Honecker pooh-poohed suggestions of wrongdoing and held an almost invariably spoken belief that his escape was a heroic enterprise. Likewise,